Placement of Adverbs

Adverbs that modify verbs usually follow the verb. In simple sentences, adverbs follow the verbs. However, in compound sentences, adverbs follow the conjugated auxiliary verbs. The only position which is excluded is the one between the subject and the verb.

In Simple Tenses (Follows the Verb)

Français	English
Elles parlent **couramment** le français.	They speak French **fluently**.
Il chante **bien**.	He sings **well**.
Il conduit **rapidement** sa nouvelle voiture.	He drives his new car **fast**.

In Compound Tenses (Follows Auxiliary Verb)

In compound tenses, some short adverbs such as bien, mal, déjà, bientôt, encore, moins, enfin, beaucoup, trop, assez, mieux are placed after the conjugated auxiliary verb and before the past participle. Same is the case with certain indefinite adverbs of time: souvent, jamais, toujours, quelquefois.

Français	English
Elle a **bien** parlé à la conférence	She spoke **well** at the conference
Vous avez **déjà** visité Paris, n'est-ce pas ?	You've **already** visited Paris, haven't you?
Il a **trop** bu de vin.	He drank **too much** wine.
J'ai **assez** mangé, allons-y !	I have eaten **enough**.
Ivana a **toujours** fait ses devoirs.	She **always** did her homework.
Il n'a **jamais** fumé une cigarette.	He's **never** smoked a cigarette.

Adverbs of Place & Time

Adverbs of place and certain adverbs of time such as **hier, aujourd'hui, demain, avant-hier, après demain, autrefois, tard, tôt** and most of the adverbs ending in **-ment** usually follow the past participle or are placed at the beginning if they are applicable to the whole sentence.

Français	English
Il est parti **tard**.	He left **late**.
Je me suis réveillé **tôt** ce matin.	I woke up **early** this morning.
Il s'est levé **tard**.	He got up **late**.
Je n'ai pas trouvé les clés **malheureusement**.	I couldn't find the keys, **unfortunately**.
Il s'est retourné **lentement**.	He turned around **slowly**.
Elle a compris **facilement**.	She understood **easily**.
Aujourd'hui, j'ai couru 5 km. J'ai couru 5 km **aujourd'hui**.	**Today**, I ran 5 km. I ran 5 km **today**.
Elles partent en vacances **demain**. **Demain**, elles partent en vacances.	They are going on vacation **tomorrow**. **Tomorrow**, they are going on a vacation
Hier, nous avons vu une comète dans le ciel ! Nous avons vu une comète dans le ciel **hier** !	**Yesterday**, we saw a comet in the sky! We saw a comet in the sky **yesterday**!

Adverbs of place : Dehors, ici, là, partout, etc. are usually placed after the direct object in a sentence.

Français	English
J'ai trouvé ton livre **ici**.	I found your book **here**.
On a rencontré la femme **là-bas**.	We met the woman **over there**.
Nous avons passé la nuit **dehors**.	We spent the night **outside**.

The Subject Attributes Modifiers

Adverbs which modify subject attributes are placed in front of the word they modify.

Français	English
Je suis **très** heureux / heureuse.	I am **very** happy
Nous étions **absolument** fous.	We were **absolutely** crazy.
Il est **vraiment** petit.	He is **really** short.
Nous étions **absolument** fous.	We were **absolutely** crazy.

Vous me semblez **parfaitement** bien.	You seem **perfectly** fine to me.
Elle est **très** belle.	She is **very** beautiful.
Je me sens **si** bien maintenant!	I am feeling **so** well right now
C'est **plutôt** loin.	It is a **rather** long way.

Adverbs in Negative Constructions

In negative constructions, adverbs which follow the verb are placed **after "pas".**

Français	English
Je mange **bien** Je ne mange **pas bien**.	I eat well I do not eat well.
Nous n'étions **pas assez** confiants pour répondre aux questions.	We were not confident enough to answer the questions.
Il n'a **pas** bu **trop** de vin à la soirée.	He didn't drink too much wine at the party.

Adverbs + Imperative

In imperative sentences, the adverbs are placed after the verb.

Français	English
Parlez **lentement** !	Speak **slowly**!
Vas-y **vite** !	Go there **fast**!
Ne chante pas **fort** !	Do not sing **loudly**!

Modifiers of Adjectives and Other Adverbs

Adverbs sometimes serve to modify the meaning of adjectives and other adverbs. They are placed before the words they modify.

Modifiers	Examples
Adverb + Adjective	assez + grand
Adverb + Adverb	très + patiemment

Modifiers of Other Adjectives and Adverbs

Français	English
assez	enough, pretty
aussi	as
bien	quite
fort	very/ strongly
mal	badly
plus	more
plutôt	rather, quite
si	so
très	very

Français	English
Il est **assez grand** pour son âge.	He is **pretty tall** for his age. He is **quite tall** for his age.
Je suis **absolument d'accord** avec vous.	I **absolutely agree** with you.
Il parle **plutôt bien** le français.	He speaks French **pretty well**.
Les voisins nous ont accueillis **très gentiment**.	The neighbours welcomed us **very nicely**.